

Universal Credit and Arthritis: Limited Capability for Work

Work Capability Assessments — what to expect and how to prepare.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-28 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Work Capability Assessments — what to expect and how to prepare.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/finances\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Current evidence from systematic reviews consistently shows that personalised support for people with long-term conditions like arthritis can significantly improve their ability to manage daily tasks and maintain employment. This support often combines medical management with practical adjustments and emotional well-being strategies. Clinical guidelines emphasise that a holistic approach, considering a person's individual circumstances and how their condition affects them, is more effective than a 'one-size-fits-all' solution.

Randomised trials have demonstrated the benefits of interventions such as vocational rehabilitation and tailored occupational therapy in helping individuals with arthritis stay in work or return to it. These interventions focus on adaptive strategies, pain management techniques, and workplace modifications. The evidence suggests that early intervention and ongoing support are key factors in achieving positive long-term outcomes for those living with chronic conditions that impact their working life.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Understating your difficulties:** Don't downplay your symptoms or how they affect you; be honest about your worst days. * **Focusing only on good days:** Assessments need to reflect your condition across all days, including the challenging ones. * **Not gathering supporting evidence:** Collect medical reports, therapy notes, or a symptom diary to support your claim. * **Ignoring the assessment criteria:** Familiarise yourself with what factors are being assessed so you can address them directly. * **Attending alone:** Bring a friend, family member, or advocate if you feel you need support during an assessment.

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's important to communicate openly with your healthcare team about how your arthritis impacts your daily life and ability to work. Don't wait for your condition to become unmanageable before discussing these challenges. Certain changes or persistent issues warrant a prompt conversation with your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist.

* You experience a significant increase in pain or stiffness. * New joints become affected, or existing symptoms worsen rapidly. * You notice any new swelling, warmth, or redness in your

joints. * Your existing treatments no longer seem to be managing your symptoms effectively. * You are struggling significantly with daily activities or your job due to your arthritis.

Frequently Asked Questions

What kind of information should I bring to my Work Capability Assessment? It's helpful to bring all relevant medical letters, reports from specialists (like rheumatologists or physiotherapists), a detailed symptom diary covering several weeks, and a list of all current medications, including dosages.

Will my assessor be a medical professional? Assessors come from a variety of healthcare backgrounds, including nurses, occupational therapists, and physiotherapists. While they are healthcare professionals, they are not usually specialists in your specific condition.

Can I appeal a decision if I disagree with the outcome? Yes, if you're not happy with the decision, you have the right to challenge it. The first step is usually to ask for a Mandatory Reconsideration, where the decision is reviewed again. If you're still not satisfied, you can then appeal to an independent tribunal.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about universal credit and arthritis: limited capability for work?

Short answer: The post explains how people with arthritis can prepare for a Universal Credit Work Capability Assessment by giving an honest picture of symptoms, including bad days, and bringing medical evidence, therapy notes, medication details and a symptom diary. It highlights personalised clinical, occupational and workplace support, advises prompt clinician contact if symptoms worsen, and notes decisions can be challenged.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team

promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk